FRONT ROW RIGHTS



With the JD(U) taking both deputy CM chairs, and BJP colleague Samrat Choudhary promoted as Bihar CM, ex-deputy CM **Vijay Kumar Sinha** is finding it difficult to adjust to the new pecking order. At the special assembly session convened for the trust vote, Sinha arrived to find the prized front row already full, occupied by the new CM and his two JD(U) deputies, Vijay K. Choudhary and Bijendra P. Yadav, along with others. The second row had seats, but that, evidently, would not do. With some firmness, Sinha had those manning the front bench make space for him too. Guess, in Sinha's book, where you sit is who you are.

DEVIL IN DETAILS



Actor-politician **Vijay** has hailed the "unprecedented" 84 per cent-plus voter turnout in the recent Tamil Nadu election, crediting the state's women and youth for it. The data, though, tells a more restrained story. While turnout has been the highest on record, the increase in actual voters is modest, about 2.1 million, and broadly consistent with the growth in the population. At the same time, the electorate has shrunk by over 5 million after the Election Commission's roll revision. Now whether all this translates into voter magic for the superstar will be clear on results day.

FAKE VERSUS ORIGINAL



It was the launch of her new party, and **K. Kavitha,** the estranged daughter of ex-CM K. Chandrasekhar Rao (KCR), was breathing fire, declaring that his Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) had lost its soul and that he had turned into a *mara manishi* (robot) controlled by "jackals". But among the invectives, it was her choice of party name, Telangana Rashtra Sena or TRS, that riled the BRS the most. For, till 2022, that was the acronym it used for the Telangana Rashtra Samithi. In a spirited response, BRS social media handles posted the original and duplicate photos of a popular toothpaste brand, with the advisory: 'The original is always the original.'

Kaushik Deka* with *Rahul Noronha, Avaneesh Mishra, Amitabh Srivastava, Kavitha Muralidharan* and *Prasad Nichenametla

SCIENCE WATCH

By **Jumana Shah**

NEW SPACEPORTS
MAKING LAUNCHES CHEAPER

Gujarat has identified a site for a satellite launch facility on its Saurashtra coastline, between the Union territory of Diu and Kodinar in Gir Somnath district. Science and technology minister Arjun Modhwadia has said that land acquisition and administrative clearances will be initiated "in the near future".

The launchpad facility would be India's first orbital launch resource on the west coast and the third spaceport in the country after the long-serving Satish Dhawan Space Centre (SDSC) at Sriharikota in Andhra Pradesh and the upcoming SSLV (small satellite launch vehicle) Launch Complex at Kulasekarapattinam in Tamil Nadu. Gujarat's Arabian Sea frontage opens trajectories suited to geostationary and specialised commercial constellation launches that east coast sites handle less efficiently.

Meanwhile, the spaceport in Tamil Nadu is in a more advanced stage. The SSLV complex in Kulasekarapattinam, a coastal village in Thoothukudi district, was chosen to fix a particular problem. Rockets from Sriharikota heading to polar orbit must curve mid-flight to avoid Sri Lanka, burning extra fuel. From Kulasekarapattinam, launches can head directly south over the Indian Ocean without crossing any land mass, eliminating the detour and recovering payload capacity.



ANI

The TN facility spans 2,233 acres and will cost Rs 950 crore. It will house 35 installations, including a launch pad, rocket integration facilities, and a mobile launch structure capable of handling 24 satellite launches a year. Notably, it will also serve private launch firms, part of India's push to open its space sector to commercial players.